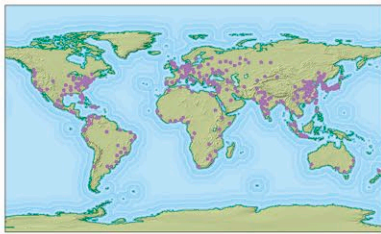


Urban areas

Two hundred years ago, only about 3 percent of the world's population lived in cities. Today, the figure is rapidly approaching 50 percent even in previously rural countries, and the human population has increased nearly sevenfold. This phenomenal growth in urban living has transformed large areas of the planet. It has created a wide range of artificial habitats—both in and out of doors—that animals can use as their homes, as well as vast amounts of waste that form the basis of animal food chains. As a result, there is a wealth of wildlife living with and among us.



CITIES that have a population of more than one million people are spread throughout the world. There are more than 250 of these cities, and the total is rapidly increasing.

Outdoors

For animals that can deal with disturbance, cities and towns can be good places to live. They have plenty of suitable places for sheltering or raising young, from trees and window ledges to underground passageways, and for omnivorous species, they provide a constant supply of leftover food. In winter, the artificial heat that escapes from buildings offers additional benefit. Even better, cities are relatively safe: cats and dogs aside, they are free of many of the predators that animals would encounter in their natural homes.

Animals have adapted to urban expansion with different degrees of success. Some species are never found in cities, always retreating as the concrete advances. Others, such as migrating birds and insects, are occasional visitors, touching down briefly before moving on. More adaptable animals—raccoons and red foxes, for example—are equally at home in town or country, and treat built-up areas as extensions of their natural habitat. True urban specialists, such as the ubiquitous feral pigeon and the house sparrow, are now so fully adapted to city living that they are rarely seen anywhere else.

While feral pigeons can survive in the busiest city centers, many urban animals are found chiefly in parks and gardens—the small-scale versions of their habitats in the wild. These animals vary from one part of the world to another, but they include tree-dwelling mammals, such as squirrels and opossums, and a wide range of birds. The spread of suburbia is normally a threat to wildlife, but for these species it can actually be a help because it creates a patchwork of suitable habitats, sometimes with the bonus of food hand outs.



FERAL PIGEONS, a familiar sight in the city, are descended from domestic birds that escaped into the wild.



THE HOUSE SPARROW'S exploitation of urban areas has enabled it to spread from Europe, Africa, and Asia, to other parts of the world.



THE BRUSH-TAILED POSSUM thrives in gardens and parks, and sometimes breeds in buildings.



MANY BUTTERFLIES breed in urban areas, but the Camberwell beauty is only a visitor in search of nectar and fallen fruit.



THE RED FOX is active at night, reducing the risk of its being disturbed while foraging.



THE BROWN RAT'S burrowing lifestyle enables it to live close to people without being easily seen.

ROOFTOPS

LIVING AREAS

GROUND

